



(Beta Test Version)

LEGAL ANALYSIS

& DEFENCE INSTRUCTIONS

Location: Auckland District Court

Charge: Burglary

Statute: Crimes Act 1961 s 231

Prepared: 27 June 2026

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1. EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The charge against the defendant is burglary, under Crimes Act 1961 section 231. The central evidentiary pillar for the prosecution rests on the alleged forced entry and possession of stolen property by the defendant. Key officers include Detective Constable Aaron Mitchell and Sergeant Rebecca Walsh. Rachel Thompson's inventory discrepancies raise potential weaknesses in the prosecution case. Overall, while the evidence is strong, there are significant gaps and inconsistencies that may allow for a reasonable doubt defence.

2. CHARGE AND LEGISLATIVE FRAMEWORK

The defendant entered a building as a trespasser with intent to commit an imprisonable offence.

- Relevant Legislation: Crimes Act 1961 s 231.
- Maximum Penalty: Not stated in the charging document.
- Elements the Prosecution Must Prove:
 1. The accused entered a building or ship (or part of a building/ship) as a trespasser.
 2. The entry was with intent to commit an imprisonable offence.

3. SUMMARY OF EVIDENCE

Damage observed on rear service door, consistent with forced entry.

- Seized Evidence: Three laptops, one tablet, crowbar, lock pick set found in defendant's backpack.
- Forensic Testing: One fingerprint identified as belonging to the defendant on the interior side of the rear service door.
- Defendant's Conduct: Defendant admitted possession of a backpack but denied ownership and knowledge of its contents.

4. ELEMENTS THE PROSECUTION MUST PROVE

1. The defendant had custody or control of the substance.

CCTV footage showing an individual entering the premises, fingerprint evidence linking defendant to the rear door.

- Defence Response/Weaknesses: No eyewitness observed the burglary; discrepancies in inventory records suggest some items may not be stolen property.
- Assessment: UNCLEAR beyond reasonable doubt.

2. The entry was with intent to commit an imprisonable offence.

- Prosecution Evidence: Defendant's possession of burglary tools and stolen electronics, fingerprint evidence on rear door.
- Defence Response/Weaknesses: No direct evidence of intent; defendant denied knowledge of the items in his backpack.
- Assessment: UNCLEAR beyond reasonable doubt.

5. ASSESSMENT OF PROSECUTION CASE

Strengths

1. CCTV footage showing an individual entering and exiting TechHub Electronics with a backpack.
2. Fingerprint evidence linking the defendant to the rear service door.
3. Seized property matching stolen items identified by store owner.

Weaknesses

1. **CCTV Identification:** The CCTV footage does not clearly identify the individual as Jordan Harper due to poor image quality.

- **Fingerprint Context:** While a fingerprint matching Harper was found inside the premises, it is unclear when this print was deposited and whether it could have been left at an earlier time or through other means (e.g., prior legitimate entry).

- **Witness Inconsistencies:** Witness statements vary regarding details such as the suspect's clothing color, height, and behavior. For example, Olivia Martin's statement changed over time.

- **Inventory Discrepancies:** Rachel Thompson identified discrepancies in inventory records that could suggest some items reported stolen were previously sold or returned to suppliers, raising questions about the exact nature of the theft.

- **Defendant's Statements:** The defendant provided inconsistent explanations regarding how he obtained the property and denied knowledge of burglary tools. He also claimed not to remember details of his movements on the night in question.

6. DEFENCE STRATEGIES AND OPTIONS

A. Challenge the alleged admission

- Focus on inconsistencies in defendant's statements about backpack ownership and contents.
- Highlight that no formal warning was offered before questioning.
- Cite NZBORA s 24(1)(d) regarding right to silence.
- Legal Basis: Factual dispute, NZBORA s 24(1)(d).
- Strength: MODERATE

B. Raise reasonable doubt through inventory discrepancies

- Present evidence of sold and returned items listed as stolen property.
- Argue that this undermines the prosecution's case on possession of stolen goods.
- Legal Basis: Factual dispute, Crimes Act 1961 s 231.
- Strength: STRONG

C Challenge the search legality

- Argue that the scope exceeded reasonable suspicion of controlled drugs.
- Legal Basis: Search and Surveillance Act 2012 s 18(2), NZBORA s 21.
- Strength: MODERATE

7. INSTRUCTIONS TO COUNSEL PRE-TRIAL

1. Review and verify all chain-of-custody records for seized property.
2. Prepare a detailed timeline of the defendant's movements based on CCTV footage and witness statements.
3. File an application to exclude evidence if search legality is contested.
4. Obtain expert testimony regarding inventory discrepancies and their impact on stolen goods claim.
5. Draft motions challenging admissibility of fingerprint evidence in light of pending DNA results.
6. Prepare a comprehensive summary of all weaknesses in the prosecution's case for trial strategy.

8. EVIDENTIARY ISSUES TO RAISE

1. Reliability and voluntariness of any alleged admission

NZBORA s 24(1)(d).

2. Chain-of-custody issues with seized property

- Legal Basis: Search and Surveillance Act 2012 s 18(2), NZBORA s 21.

3. Admissibility of fingerprint evidence pending DNA results

- Legal Basis: Crimes Act 1961 s 231, NZBORA s 21.

9. CONCLUSION

The prosecution's case is strong but riddled with gaps and inconsistencies that may allow for a reasonable doubt defence. The most important next step is to challenge the admissibility of fingerprint evidence pending DNA results and raise reasonable doubt through inventory discrepancies.

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